PersianPulse

EVIDENCE DESK

Do multivitamins prevent disease?

What NIH and large trials say about healthy adults



Evidence of benefit

Early | Limited | Moderate | Strong

for preventing chronic disease in healthy adults

WHAT THE RESEARCH FOUND

- NIH: multivitamins do not appear to reliably reduce the risk of chronic diseases.
- Physicians' Health Study II (about 14,600 men, median 11.2 years): 8% lower cancer risk, no fewer major cardiovascular events.

WHO MAY BENEFIT

- People with restricted diets, such as strict vegan diets.
- Women who could become pregnant (400 mcg folic acid a day).
- Adults 50 and older, who may need vitamin B12 from fortified foods or supplements.

BE CAREFUL

- Stacking supplements and fortified foods can push intake above upper limits.
- Smokers are advised to avoid products with large amounts of beta-carotene or vitamin A.
- Ask a health professional first, especially if you take warfarin.

39.4% of US adults 60 and older took a multivitamin in the past 30 days (NHANES 2017–2018)

> **Food comes first. Multivitamins do not appear to reliably prevent chronic disease, but some people have specific needs.**

Sources: NIH Office of Dietary Supplements, Multivitamin/mineral supplements fact sheet (health professionals)

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